

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ 5
♥ Q 10 9 8 2
♦ 9 2
♣ 9 8 6 5 4

♠ A 8 4
♥ A J 3
♦ Q 10 6 5
♣ A K Q

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q J 10 9 3
♥ K 7 6 4
♦ A
♣ J 10 3

♠ K 7 6 2
♥ 5
♦ K J 8 7 4 3
♣ 7 2

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	5♦		
All Pass			

5♦ by North

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If West has a singleton ♠, and East has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. East will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K West will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when East wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. West may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - West will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that West has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

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Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

North plays 5♦. East leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT East might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Board 2

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 7
 ♥ K 10 9 2
 ♦ 7 6
 ♣ K Q J 8 2

♠ K 8 3 2

♥ 7 6 3

♦ A J 10 4

♣ A 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 9 5 4
 ♥ J 8
 ♦ 9 5 3
 ♣ 10 9 6 5

♠ A J 6

♥ A Q 5 4

♦ K Q 8 2

♣ 7 3

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

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You were hoping for a ♠ response, but so be it. You now bid 3NT, knowing partner will correct to 4♠ if he was 4-4 in the Majors, or pass if he doesn't have 4 ♠s. He passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT.

West leads the ♣K, East follows with the ♣10. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

It makes no difference whether you hold up or not, (unless their ♣s are 7-2), so go ahead and take the first trick.

Either the ♥Q or the ♠J **MIGHT** become your ninth trick.

If you try either finesse and it wins you will make your contract. If you try either finesse and it loses you will be set immediately with ♣s. Each finesse is a 50% shot.

Is there anything you can do to improve your chances?

Of course - otherwise the question wouldn't have been asked! You can combine two chances. Obviously you cannot take both finesses, but you can try to drop the ♠Q in two pulls, and if she doesn't drop you still have the ♥ finesse to fall back on. So win the ♣A, play 4 ♦ winners and the ♠ A K, then see whether you have to try the ♥ finesse.

Aha - the ♠Q dropped so you take your 9 tricks.

But if she hadn't, you'd still have a 50% chance in ♥s.

Board 3

South Deals

E-W Vul

♠ J 10 8 4

♥ K 7 5 3

♦ J 10 9 3

♣ 8

♠ K 6 2

♥ A Q

♦ 5 4

♣ K Q J 9 7 2



♠ Q 9 5

♥ 10 9 8 4 2

♦ K 8

♣ 10 5 4

♠ A 7 3

♥ J 6

♦ A Q 7 6 2

♣ A 6 3

West

North

East

South

Pass

3♣

Pass

4♣

Pass

6♣

All Pass

6♣ by North

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

With partner agreeing ♣s, one possibility would be for you to cue-bid your ♥A. Another would be just to bid 6♣. You choose the second approach.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♥10. West plays low and you win the ♥Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Your best chance at another winner is the ♦ suit. East MAY have both the ♦ K Q, if not you will have to establish the suit.

At trick 2 pull just one round of trumps with the ♣K. Then play a small ♦, finessing the ♦J when East plays low. West takes the ♦Q and returns the ♠J.

Go up with your ♠K, you may need the entry to dummy later. Pull one more trump with the ♣Q, then play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. Ruff a ♦ with a high trump, East discarding.

Enter dummy with the ♣A, pulling East's last trump as you do, and ruff one more ♦, establishing the fifth ♦. Enter dummy with the ♠A and discard your losing ♠ on the good ♦.

It is important to be careful with entries to the hand where you are trying to establish a suit.

If the suit splits evenly perhaps you can be a little sloppy and still get by.

But in cases like this one, with a 4-2 split, you cannot afford to waste an entry too early.

Board 4

South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 9 8
♥ K J
♦ Q 9 8 5
♣ Q J 3

♠ 6
♥ A 7 5 3 2
♦ 7 6 4 2
♣ 8 5 4

W N E
S

♠ K 7 4 3
♥ Q 10 9 4
♦ J 10
♣ K 10 7

♠ A 10 5 2
♥ 8 6
♦ A K 3
♣ A 9 6 2

West	North	East	South
Pass	2♦	Pass	1NT
All Pass			2♥

2♥ by South
to say that 1NT would be an inferior contract. Here's a suggestion - with fewer than 9 points and a 5-card Major transfer to that suit when you have a singleton, pass with no singleton. So here you bid 2♦ and partner says 2♥.

Of course you pass, that was the whole point of the transfer.

The contract would be 2♥ played by North.

South plays 2♥. West leads the ♠Q, East playing the ♠7.

We will all agree that you win the first trick with your ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2/3/? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = lots

In suit contracts it is usual to count losers. Sometimes in low level suit contracts it makes things clearer if you count winners. Here you have 4 high card winners in your hand plus the Ace of trumps in dummy.

Your plan will therefore be to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can.

At trick 2 ruff a ♠ in dummy. Pull one trump with the ♥A. Play a ♣ back to your ♣A and ruff another ♠.

Got the idea? Play a ♦ to your ♦K and ruff your last ♠ in dummy. Then play the ♦A. If you've been counting you have taken the first 8 tricks. A good thing, too, because you aren't going to take any more.

In most suit contracts it is good to pull trumps early.

Here is an example of when that principle is **NOT** correct; when you need to get several ruffs with small trumps.

This situation comes up a lot. You don't have enough points to advance partner's 1NT opening, but you have a "long suit" that might play better than notrump. If "long suit" is 6 ♥s or 6 ♠s then pretty clearly you should transfer partner to that suit and then pass. But with only 5 of the Major it is tougher to say that 1NT would be an inferior contract. Here's a suggestion - with fewer than 9 points and a 5-card Major, transfer to that suit when you have a singleton or void, otherwise pass 1NT. So here you bid 2♦ and partner says 2♥.

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